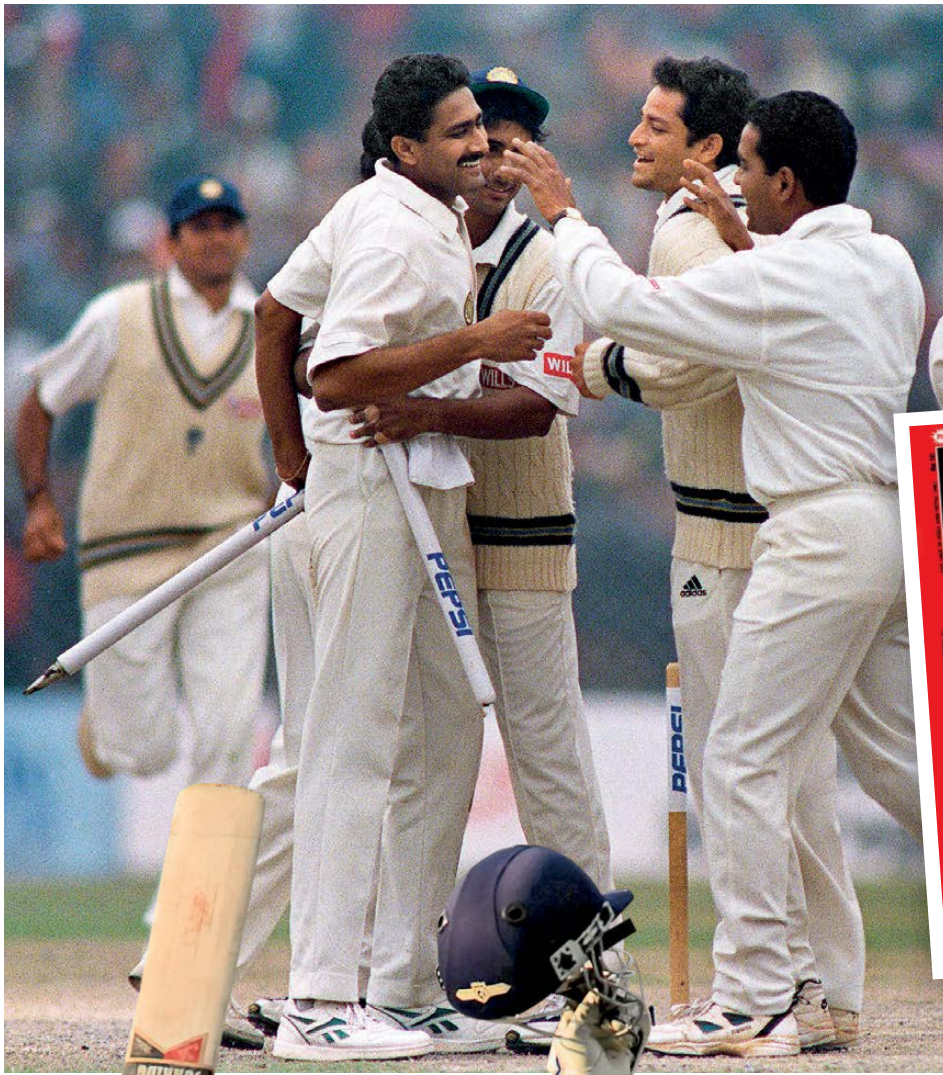
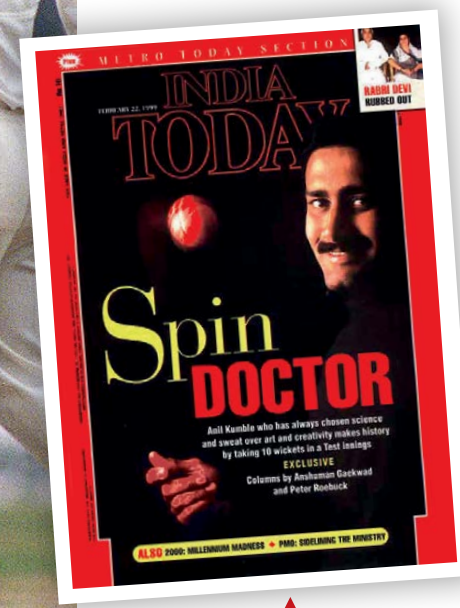
AFP



50TH ANNIVERSARY

SPORTS
1995-2005



Feb. 22, 1999



GETTY IMAGES

LANDMARK MOMENTS (Left) Anil Kumble takes another Pakistani wicket en route to his 10-wicket haul in Delhi, Feb. 1999; (below) V.V.S. Laxman reaches his 100 against Australia in Kolkata, Mar. 2001. He would go on to make a career-defining 281

est face of the bat ever by an Indian batting unit: If Viru doesn't get you, Sachin must; if 'the Wall' doesn't ground you to dust, VVS would caressingly spank you to all corners. From 2000 to 2005, when the outfit was at their peak, it was led by Ganguly, who chucked provincialism and infused a tough-as-nails aggression. After the damage wrought by the match-fixing scandal, Indian cricket needed that. This team was the first to convincingly win overseas Tests—in England, Australia and Pakistan. In ODIs, they won at a much higher rate, and swept all before them in the 2003 World Cup before falling in the final. The pinnacle came in the 2001 Test series win against Australia; individual highlights remain Kumble's 10 wickets in an innings versus Pakistan in 1999, Harbhajan's hat-trick against the Aussies in 2001 and Laxman's very, very special 281—the gold standard of batting in adversity. ■

GANGULY'S AGGRESSIVE CAPTAINCY INFUSED A CAN-DO SPIRIT. THE TEAM WON TESTS ABROAD AND REACHED THE 2003 WORLD CUP FINAL IN SOUTH AFRICA